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Intelligence Briefing

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■ AI-GENERATED CONTENT

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY (BLUF)

Ukraine's sustained defense and counter-strikes are eroding Russian military capacity, while Russia's nuclear exercises with Belarus signal escalation risks. Simultaneously, Iran's de facto control over the Strait of Hormuz poses a direct threat to European energy security, prompting NATO to consider escort operations.

KEY DEVELOPMENTS

- Ukraine's territorial gains and successful deep strikes into Russian defense industrial and oil infrastructure
- Russia-Belarus nuclear exercises and deployment of nuclear weapons in Belarus, signaling escalation readiness
- Iran's institutionalization of control over Strait of Hormuz, with NATO considering escort mission from July
- US-Iran negotiations stall over uranium enrichment and Strait of Hormuz, with Trump canceling a planned strike
- Russia-China Power of Siberia-2 pipeline deal fails, highlighting economic constraints on Moscow

MILITARY OPERATIONS IN UKRAINE

Ukraine continues to hold and stabilize the frontline, with recent territorial gains following Russian forces' loss of access to Starlink in early February 2026. Ukrainian long-range and mid-range strike campaigns have imposed increasing costs on Russian forces, including an average of 1,021 casualties per day in 2026. On May 16-17, Ukrainian forces struck multiple Russian defense industrial plants and oil infrastructure in Moscow City and Oblast, including the Angstrom Semiconductor Plant and the Moscow Oil Refinery. Russia responded with a large-scale strike of 546 drones and missiles on May 17-18, targeting civilian infrastructure in Dnipro and Odesa. Ukraine's Fortress Belt of four large cities remains critical to sustaining a defensible frontline, and Russia's negotiation strategy seeks to secure political control of this terrain without a fight.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 22, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 18, 2026

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 17, 2026
- Ukraine's Fortress Belt: The Key to Sustaining the Frontline

RUSSIAN NUCLEAR POSTURING AND BELARUS INTEGRATION

Russia and Belarus completed combined nuclear exercises on May 21, with Russian President Putin and Belarusian President Lukashenko presiding over the second stage of exercises that included delivery of nuclear munitions to Belarus. Russia conducted an unannounced strategic nuclear exercise from May 19-21 involving over 64,000 personnel and 200 missile launchers, significantly earlier in the year than typical Grom exercises. These exercises highlight Russia's deepening de facto control over Belarus and its willingness to leverage nuclear threats to distract from battlefield weaknesses. Putin announced plans for the biennial Union Shield exercises in 2027, which may include a nuclear component for the first time.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 21, 2026
- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 19, 2026

IRAN'S STRAIT OF HORMUZ THREAT AND EUROPEAN RESPONSE

Iran is using the ceasefire period to normalize its protection racket in the Strait of Hormuz, demanding vessels pay fees for 'security' that is effectively protection from Iranian attacks. Iran's counterproposal in US negotiations does not meet US demands on highly enriched uranium or the strait, and Iranian officials have coalesced around demands to formalize control over strait transit. Some NATO countries reportedly support a plan to escort ships through the Strait of Hormuz beginning in early July, though unanimous support is lacking. The South Korean government is considering phased participation in the US-led Maritime Freedom Construct after an Iranian-linked attack on a South Korean-operated vessel. Iran's actions pose a direct threat to European energy security, as the strait is a critical chokepoint for oil and gas shipments.

Sources:

- Iran Update Special Report, May 22, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 21, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 20, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 19, 2026
- Iran Update Special Report, May 18, 2026
- Korean Peninsula Update, May 19, 2026

RUSSIA-CHINA RELATIONS AND ECONOMIC CONSTRAINTS

Russian President Putin's official visit to China failed to secure a signed agreement on the Power of Siberia-2 pipeline, demonstrating the limits of Russo-Sino cooperation. Only comparatively minor bilateral agreements were signed, while China leveraged its upper hand to extract concessions. The failure to finalize the pipeline deal underscores Russia's economic pressure from sanctions and the war in Ukraine, as it seeks alternative revenue sources. Bloomberg reported that some senior Kremlin officials believe the war has reached a 'dead end,' but Putin remains committed to seizing Donetsk and Luhansk oblasts by end of 2026.

Sources:

- Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, May 20, 2026

OUTLOOK

Ukraine will likely continue to exploit Russian logistical vulnerabilities and sustain long-range strikes, while Russia may escalate nuclear rhetoric and pressure on Belarus. The Strait of Hormuz crisis will likely lead to increased NATO naval presence, potentially escalating tensions with Iran and further straining European energy security.